



Over 1,500 prints of movies were routinely released, and in *Ghajini's* case, in 22 countries

spawning a younger version, *Uttaran*, by the year-end, and competing with an assorted cast of crazies, from *Bigg Boss's* dysfunctional characters to *Khatron ke Khiladi's* girls with guts to MTV *Roadies's* expletive-spewing youngsters. Superstars made an appointment with their subjects every evening, with *Kya Aap Paanchvi Pass Se Tez Hain*, *Dus ka Dum* and *Khatron ke Khiladi* charming them with their wit and wisdom on assorted game shows. But even on the small screen, stories of domestic abuse and female empowerment propelled an unlikely show, *Aap Ki Kachehri* *Kiran ke Saath*, into the top 10

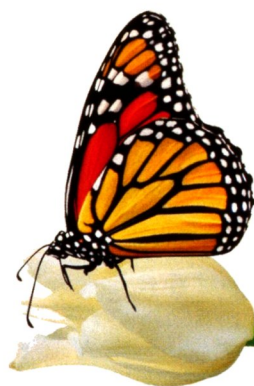
of programming.

Which brings us to the other great unveiling of 2008. Girl power was everywhere. *Face hai bhola/andar se bum ka gola*. That's how Akshay Kumar described his psychology-studying heroine who thought nothing of thrashing a handbag snatcher in *Singh is Kinng*. Women wowed in Bollywood, as Priyanka Chopra shouldered *Fashion's* biting expose and Kareena Kapoor outshone a bunch of boys in *Golmaal Returns*. Sex came into the bedroom and gays and lesbians tumbled out of the closet. Boman Irani's flamboyant gay fashion editor ogled at Abhishek Bachchan in

Dostana while Samir Soni's gay designer threw meaningful looks at his toy boy in *Fashion's* front row. It was about time too: Bollywood gay mafia is as ubiquitous as it is firmly closeted.

It was also a year where Bollywood broke ever-new social barriers. A movie title was appropriated to describe a prime minister's handling of the nuclear deal (Singh is King declared a certain SMS to editors referring to Manmohan Singh), starlets in television debates made more sense than politicians on the Mumbai blasts and star face-offs made as much news as star hook-ups. Was anything immune to a little sprinkling

ended on television when *Kasautii Zindagii Kay*, *Kahaani Ghar Ghar Kii* and then *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi* went off the air. An unlikely new channel, Colors, decided to tell the story of a child marriage in contemporary Rajasthan and a 10-year-old became television's new darling,



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